

Word family: spirit / spirits / spirited / spiritual / spiritually / spirituality

Base word: spirit

Plural: spirits

Related forms: spirited, spiritual, spiritually, spirituality

Useful expressions / extensions: strong spirit, in good/high spirits, in low spirits, team spirit, fighting spirit, spirit of something, free spirit

Part of speech: mainly noun (名詞) / adjective-related family (相關形容詞)

Your sentence:

“Although she is quite small and physically frail, she has an incredibly strong spirit.”

Meaning in this passage

Here, spirit means a person's inner emotional and mental strength—the part of their character that gives them courage, determination, resilience, and the ability to continue through hardship.

It does not refer to a ghost or supernatural being.

Your passage deliberately contrasts:

physically frail

with:

strong spirit

So her body may be relatively weak, while her inner character and determination remain powerful.

繁體中文：一個人內在的精神力量、意志和韌性，使其即使面對困難、痛苦或挫折，也能保持堅強並繼續面對生活

中文翻譯：

“Although she is quite small and physically frail, she has an incredibly strong spirit.”

「雖然她身形瘦小，而且身體比較虛弱，但她有非常堅強的精神和意志力。」

Here:

strong spirit = 內心有很強的意志、勇氣和韌性，不容易被困難擊倒

1. spirit = inner strength / courage / determination (內在精神力量) — 精神；意志；韌性

This is the exact sense in your passage.

Practice 1 — Original

“She has an incredibly strong spirit.”

「她有非常堅強的精神和意志力。」

Practice 2

“Even after years of hardship, her spirit remained strong.”

「即使經歷多年困難，她的精神和意志仍然非常堅強。」

Practice 3

“His illness weakened his body but never broke his spirit.”

「疾病令他的身體變得虛弱，卻從沒有擊垮他的意志和精神。」

spirit = 一個人面對困難時所展現的內在勇氣、意志、生命力和韌性

2. spirits = mood / emotional state (情緒 / 心情) — 精神狀態；情緒

The plural spirits has an important lexicalized meaning.

Practice 4

“She was in good spirits after seeing her family.”

「見過家人後，她心情很好 / 精神很好。」

Practice 5

“His spirits improved when he heard the good news.”

「聽到好消息後，他的心情好轉了。」

spirits = 一個人在某個時刻的情緒或精神狀態

Usually found in expressions such as:

in good spirits

in high spirits

in low spirits

raise/lift someone's spirits

This plural meaning is important because it does not simply mean several “spirits” in the sense of souls.

3. in high spirits — 情緒高昂；興高采烈

Practice 6

“The children were in high spirits during the celebration.”

「孩子們在慶祝活動期間都興高采烈、情緒高昂。」

Practice 7

“She arrived in high spirits and talked to everyone.”

「她到達時心情非常好、精神高昂，跟每個人都聊天。」

in high spirits = 心情非常愉快、活潑而有精神

4. in low spirits — 情緒低落；心情不好

Practice 8

“He had been in low spirits since losing his job.”

「失去工作後，他一直情緒低落。」

Practice 9

“She seemed a little in low spirits that afternoon.”

「那天下午她似乎有點悶悶不樂 / 心情低落。」

in low spirits = 心情低沉、缺乏愉快或積極情緒

5. lift / raise someone's spirits — 振奮某人的心情；令某人開心起來

Practice 10

“Her grandmother's phone call lifted her spirits.”

「外婆的一通電話令她心情振作起來。」

Practice 11

“A walk outside helped raise his spirits.”

「到外面走一走令他的心情好了起來。」

lift someone's spirits = 令原本低落或疲倦的人重新變得較開心、有精神

6. spirit = characteristic attitude / energy (某人的氣質 / 精神面貌) — 精神 ; 氣概

Here, spirit refers to the characteristic energy or attitude someone shows.

Practice 12

"I admire her independent spirit."

「我很欣賞她那種獨立自主的精神。」

Practice 13

"The young athlete showed great competitive spirit."

「那位年輕運動員展現出很強的競爭精神 / 鬥志。」

spirit = 一個人在行為和態度中表現出來的特定精神、氣質或意志

Common:

independent spirit

adventurous spirit

competitive spirit

generous spirit

7. fighting spirit — 鬥志 ; 不服輸的精神

A particularly useful extension of the previous sense.

Practice 14

"The team showed great fighting spirit after falling behind."

「球隊落後後仍展現出強大的鬥志。」

Practice 15

"She never lost her fighting spirit during treatment."

「她在治療期間從沒有失去自己的鬥志和不放棄的精神。」

fighting spirit = 面對困境、競爭或挫折仍然願意繼續努力、不肯輕易放棄的精神

This is closely related to the strong spirit in your original passage.

8. team spirit — 團隊精神

Practice 16

“Good communication helps build team spirit.”

「良好溝通有助建立團隊精神。」

Practice 17

“The manager organized activities to improve team spirit.”

「經理安排了一些活動來提升團隊精神和凝聚力。」

team spirit = 團隊成員之間互相支持、合作並認同共同目標的精神

This does not mean an individual person's soul; it describes a shared group attitude.

9. community/school spirit — 團體認同感；集體精神

Practice 18

“The festival created a strong sense of community spirit.”

「這個節慶營造出很強的社區凝聚力和集體精神。」

Practice 19

“Students wore the school colours to show school spirit.”

「學生穿上學校代表色，以展示對學校的認同感和團體精神。」

spirit = 群體成員對共同身份、目標或團體所表現的熱情、忠誠和凝聚力

This extends the same idea found in team spirit.

10. the spirit of + activity/age/place (核心精神 / 特質) —的精神；本質

This is a major abstract meaning.

Practice 20

“Helping each other is part of the spirit of the event.”

「互相幫助是這項活動核心精神的一部分。」

Practice 21

“The design captures the spirit of the city.”

「這個設計捕捉了這座城市的特色和精神面貌。」

the spirit of something = 某件事、地方、時代或活動最具代表性的態度、價值、氣氛或本質

11. the spirit of the law/rule — 法律 / 規則背後的原意與目的

A very important formal extension.

Practice 22

“His actions followed the spirit of the law, even if the situation was unusual.”

「他的做法符合這項法律背後的原意和精神，即使情況比較特殊。」

Practice 23

“We should respect both the wording and the spirit of the rule.”

「我們既要遵守規則的字面內容，也應尊重它背後的原意和目的。」

spirit of a law/rule = 制定法律或規則時真正想達成的目的、價值或原則，而不只是字面條文

This produces the important contrast:

letter of the law

vs

spirit of the law

12. spirit = atmosphere / feeling of an occasion (氣氛) — 精神；氣氛

Practice 24

“Everyone joined in the spirit of the celebration.”

「大家都投入了慶祝活動的歡樂氣氛。」

Practice 25

“The decorations helped create a festive spirit.”

「那些裝飾有助營造節日氣氛。」

spirit = 某個活動或場合所具有、並感染參與者的共同氣氛或情緒

This overlaps with “spirit of something” but focuses more on atmosphere.

13. spirit = soul / non-physical part of a person (靈魂) — 靈魂 ; 精神本體

This is a traditional and common meaning.

Practice 26

“Some traditions believe the spirit continues after the body dies.”

「有些傳統相信人在身體死亡後，靈魂仍會繼續存在。」

Practice 27

“The story describes the separation of body and spirit.”

「故事描述了身體與靈魂的分離。」

spirit = 被認為存在於人體之中、但並非物質身體本身的靈魂或精神本體

This is clearly different from your passage's determination/resilience sense.

14. spirit = ghost / supernatural being (鬼魂 / 靈體) — 靈體 ; 鬼魂

Practice 28

“The villagers believed a spirit lived in the old house.”

「村民相信那座老房子裡住著一個靈體 / 鬼魂。」

Practice 29

“The story is about a mysterious spirit that appears at night.”

「這個故事講述一個晚上出現的神秘鬼魂 / 靈體。」

spirit = 被認為沒有實體身體的超自然存在，尤其是鬼魂或靈體

Compare:

spirit — soul = 某人的靈魂

a spirit — supernatural being = 一個靈體 / 鬼魂

15. Spirit = divine/sacred being (宗教) — 聖靈 / 神靈

In religious language, Spirit can have a specialized meaning, often capitalized.

Practice 30

“The prayer refers to the Holy Spirit.”

「這段禱告提到聖靈。」

Practice 31

“They believed they were guided by the Spirit.”

「他們相信自己受到聖靈 / 神靈引導。」

Spirit = 宗教語境中所指的神聖靈性存在；具體意思視宗教傳統而定

Capitalization is significant in many Christian contexts.

16. spirit = supernatural being associated with nature/place (神靈；精靈)

Practice 32

“The legend tells of a forest spirit.”

「傳說講述了一個森林精靈 / 神靈。」

Practice 33

“People once believed that spirits lived in the mountains.”

「人們以前相信山中住著神靈 / 精靈。」

spirit = 傳說、宗教或民間信仰中與自然、地方或其他力量相關的非物質存在

This should not be merged with ordinary emotional spirit.

17. spirits = strong alcoholic drinks (烈酒) — 烈酒

A completely separate plural lexical meaning.

Practice 34

“The shop sells wine, beer, and spirits.”

「這間商店出售葡萄酒、啤酒和烈酒。」

Practice 35

“Passengers cannot bring large bottles of spirits through security.”

「乘客不能攜帶大瓶烈酒通過安檢。」

spirits = 酒精濃度較高、通常經過蒸餾製成的酒類

Examples include:

whisky

vodka

rum

gin

This is a genuine separate meaning of plural spirits.

18. spirited = lively, energetic, and determined (有活力 / 有鬥志的) — 精神飽滿的；有活力的

A useful related adjective.

Practice 36

“They had a spirited discussion about the issue.”

「他們就這個問題進行了一場熱烈而有活力的討論。」

Practice 37

“The team made a spirited comeback in the second half.”

「球隊在下半場作出一次充滿鬥志的反擊。」

spirited = 表現出充沛活力、熱情、勇氣或決心的

Depending on context:

spirited person = 有活力、有個性的人

spirited debate = 熱烈的辯論

spirited performance = 充滿活力的表演

19. free spirit = independent person (自由奔放的人) — 自由不羈的人

A common lexicalized expression.

Practice 38

“She has always been a free spirit who dislikes strict routines.”

「她一直都是個自由不羈、不喜歡受到規範束縛的人。」

Practice 39

“Everyone in the family sees him as a free spirit.”

「家裡每個人都把他看成一個自由奔放的人。」

free spirit = 思想和生活方式獨立，不喜歡受到傳統規範或限制束縛的人

20. kindred spirit = 志趣相投的人；心靈相通的人

Another valuable fixed expression.

Practice 40

“I immediately felt that she was a kindred spirit.”

「我立即覺得她是個跟我志趣相投、心靈相通的人。」

Practice 41

“The two artists became friends because they were kindred spirits.”

「兩位藝術家因為志趣相投而成為朋友。」

kindred spirit = 在思想、價值、性格或興趣方面與自己非常相近的人

21. spiritual = relating to the inner/non-material side of life (精神 / 靈性層面) — 精神上的；靈性的

A major related form.

Practice 42

“She finds spiritual comfort in meditation.”

「她從冥想中獲得精神 / 心靈上的安慰。」

Practice 43

“For him, the journey was a deeply spiritual experience.”

「對他來說，這趟旅程是一段非常深刻的心靈 / 靈性體驗。」

spiritual = 與人的內在心靈、靈魂、生命意義或宗教信仰有關，而不是主要涉及物質層面

22. spiritual = religious / sacred (宗教 / 信仰) — 宗教上的；靈性的

Practice 44

“He turned to a spiritual leader for guidance.”

「他向一位宗教 / 靈性領袖尋求指引。」

Practice 45

“The building has great spiritual significance for the community.”

「這座建築對該社群具有重要的宗教 / 靈性意義。」

spiritual = 與宗教信仰、神聖事物或靈性實踐有關的

This overlaps with #21, but the religious context may be more explicit.

23. spirituality = concern with inner meaning / spiritual life (靈性 ; 精神追求)

Practice 46

“She became more interested in spirituality as she grew older.”

「隨著年紀增長，她對靈性和精神層面的探索更感興趣。」

Practice 47

“For some people, spirituality is important even without formal religion.”

「對一些人來說，即使沒有正式宗教信仰，靈性追求仍然很重要。」

spirituality = 對內在生命、靈魂、人生意義、神聖事物或超越物質生活的關注與實踐

Important distinction: spirit vs mood

mood

= someone's temporary emotional state

“She is in a good mood.”

「她心情很好。」

spirit

can refer much more broadly to:

inner courage

determination

general emotional condition

group attitude
essential character
soul

When plural:

in good spirits

often overlaps closely with:

in a good mood

But spirit has a much wider semantic range.

Important distinction: spirit vs soul

These overlap strongly in religious/philosophical language but are not always interchangeable.

soul

most directly refers to:

the non-physical essence or identity of an individual.

spirit

can mean that too, but it also means:

courage
attitude
mood
atmosphere
group enthusiasm
underlying principle

So:

strong spirit

in your sentence does not naturally mean:

strong soul

It means inner resilience and determination.

Important distinction: spirit vs mind

mind

focuses mainly on:

thought

memory

reasoning

awareness

spirit

in your sentence focuses on:

courage

resilience

inner energy

determination

Therefore:

a strong mind

may suggest mental discipline or psychological toughness,

while:

a strong spirit

often feels broader and more emotional, suggesting the person cannot easily be defeated by hardship.

Important distinction: spirit vs personality

personality

= a person's characteristic pattern of behaviour, feelings, and social traits.

spirit

can describe the energy, courage, attitude, or emotional force underlying those behaviours.

For example:

“She has a quiet personality.”

and:

“She has a strong spirit.”

can both be true simultaneously.

Your grandmother in the passage is actually a good example: she is described as quiet but inwardly strong.

Important distinction: spirit vs spiritual
spirit

= noun

“She has a strong spirit.”

「她有堅強的精神。」

spiritual

= adjective

“She finds the experience spiritual.”

「她覺得這是一種心靈 / 靈性的體驗。」

Spiritual does not normally mean simply:

strong-minded

It refers to the inner, non-material, religious, or soul-related dimension.

Important distinction: spirited vs spiritual

These look very similar but mean very different things.

spirited

= lively, energetic, enthusiastic, determined

“a spirited debate”

= 一場熱烈的辯論

spiritual

= relating to the soul, inner life, religion, or non-material meaning

“a spiritual experience”

= 心靈 / 靈性體驗

Do not confuse them.

Important distinction: spirit vs spirits

Pluralization can dramatically change meaning.

spirit

“She has a strong spirit.”

= 內在意志 / 精神

spirits — mood

“She is in good spirits.”

= 心情很好

spirits — alcohol

“The shop sells spirits.”

= 商店出售烈酒

This makes spirit / spirits especially valuable polysemy material.

Important distinction: spirit of the law vs letter of the law
letter of the law

= 法律條文的字面內容

spirit of the law

= 法律背後真正的目的和原則

Someone can technically obey the:

letter

while violating the:

spirit

This is a highly useful formal contrast.

Important distinction: strong spirit vs high spirits

They look similar but mean different things.

strong spirit

= strong inner resilience and determination

「堅強的精神 / 意志」

high spirits

= very cheerful and energetic mood

「興高采烈 / 情緒高昂」

So your grandmother having:

a strong spirit

does not mean she is constantly cheerful or excited.

It means she has inner strength.

Family-extension note

Following the reference curation style, these are especially useful members and constructions of the spirit family:

strong spirit = 堅強的精神 / 意志

spirit — courage/resilience = 內在勇氣、韌性

spirits — emotional state = 心情 / 精神狀態

in high spirits = 情緒高昂

in low spirits = 情緒低落

lift someone's spirits = 振奮某人的心情

independent/adventurous spirit = 獨立 / 冒險精神

fighting spirit = 鬥志

team spirit = 團隊精神

community/school spirit = 團體認同與凝聚力

spirit of something = 某件事的核心精神 / 本質

spirit of the law = 法律背後的原意與原則

spirit — atmosphere = 氣氛 / 精神面貌

spirit — soul = 靈魂

spirit — supernatural being = 靈體 / 鬼魂

Spirit — religious = 聖靈 / 神聖靈性存在

spirits — alcohol = 烈酒

spirited = 有活力 / 有鬥志的

free spirit = 自由不羈的人

kindred spirit = 志趣相投的人

spiritual = 精神 / 靈性 / 宗教上的

spirituality = 靈性 ; 精神追求

These should not all be treated as separate meanings of bare spirit. As your reference methodology demonstrates, useful compounds, grammaticalized expressions, and related family members should be included while still distinguishing them from true lexical senses of the base word.

Master comparison

Form / sense MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning

spirit — inner strength 面對困難時使人仍能保持勇氣、意志和韌性的內在精神力量

spirits — mood 某人在某個時刻的情緒或精神狀態

in high spirits 情緒十分愉快、活潑而精神高昂

in low spirits 心情低沉、缺乏積極或愉快情緒

lift someone's spirits 令情緒低落的人重新變得較開心、有精神

independent/adventurous spirit 某人行為和態度中表現出來的特定精神、氣質或意志

fighting spirit 面對困難或競爭仍願意努力、不肯放棄的鬥志

team spirit 團隊成員互相支持、合作並認同共同目標的精神

community/school spirit 對共同群體身份所表現的熱情、忠誠和凝聚力

spirit of something 某件事、地方或時代最具代表性的態度、價值、氣氛或本質

spirit of the law 法律 / 規則背後真正想達成的目的、價值和原則

spirit — atmosphere 某場合或活動所形成並感染參與者的共同氣氛

spirit — soul 被視為存在於人體中、不同於物質身體的靈魂 / 精神本體

spirit — supernatural being 沒有普通實體身體的鬼魂、靈體或超自然存在

Spirit — sacred/religious 宗教語境中的神聖靈性存在 ; 具體意思取決於宗教傳統

spirits — alcohol 酒精濃度較高、通常經蒸餾製成的烈酒

spirited 表現出活力、熱情、勇氣或決心的

free spirit 思想和生活方式獨立、不喜歡受傳統規範限制的人

kindred spirit 在思想、價值、性格或興趣上與自己十分相近的人

spiritual — inner/non-material 與心靈、靈魂、生命意義或非物質層面有關的

spiritual — religious 與宗教信仰、神聖事物或靈性實踐有關的

spirituality 對內在生命、人生意義、靈魂或超越物質生活的關注與實踐

For your original sentence

“Although she is quite small and physically frail, she has an incredibly strong spirit.”

The exact meaning is:

spirit = 一個人內在的勇氣、意志、生命力和韌性，使其即使遇到困難也不容易被擊倒

Therefore:

a strong spirit

= 「堅強的精神 / 強大的內在意志和韌性」

The sentence creates a deliberate contrast:

physically frail

= 身體比較虛弱

but:

strong spirit

= 內心和意志非常堅強

So here spirit is specifically the person's inner resilience and determination. It is neither the ghost/soul meaning nor the spirits = mood/alcohol meanings.